

intentional spending choice you make, you free up a little more of your time and money to work for you in these areas.

Income

I recently came across a study, separate from the survey we referenced earlier, where every generation (Boomers to Gen Z) named an annual income they thought they needed to be happy. Most generations suggested something between \$130K to \$190K annually would be sufficient. Except for Millennials. We generation Y-ers cited needing to earn \$525,000 annually² to be happy.

Now before we all balk at this number and reprimand Millennials for our high debt and unrealistic dreams, the plot thickens.

There's some spicy research emerging here, and even though it sounds like those words shouldn't go together, just trust me. Grab your cup and get ready for this tea.

To answer the question "Do larger incomes make people happier?" two researchers teamed up in an adversarial collaboration.³ You read that right. Spicy research. Their own independent studies previously led them to different conclusions. You may recall these studies—they're pretty popular. The first found that happiness leveled out around the \$60K to \$90K mark, while the other study reported a linear relationship between happiness and income with no plateau. These discrepancies in findings led them to join together in an effort to find common ground in the data. What they discovered was that, yes, in most instances more money does make people happier. Literally up until about the \$500K mark, there is a positive correlation between people's reported levels of happiness and their annual income.

Okay, Millennials, hitting the nail on the head with your guesses!

But before we get a big head about it, there's an important caveat here. The positive correlation between increased income and increased emotional satisfaction is not true for people who are already unhappy. There are plenty of miserable wealthy people. And unfortunately for them, more money will not solve the problem.

Similarly, for those of us who are not already wealthy, more money will not in and of itself make us happy long-term. But our ability to find